JOHN JALSEVAC, PHD

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SUMMARY

Strategic development and communications leader with broad experience spanning fundraising, donor relations, team management, and integrated business development and marketing. Adept at building and leading high-trust teams, crafting compelling story-focused narratives for mission-driven institutions, and connecting with donor and donor-prospects through intentional relationship-building. Brings deep academic formation in the arts tradition at the University of Toronto and a strong fit with Wolf Scholars' emphasis on intellectual depth and breadth, leadership development, and cultivating exceptional students through a high-touch, cohort-based, arts-focused program.

EDUCATION

PhD, Philosophy, University of Toronto (Centre for Medieval Studies) 2018 - 2023

- Member of the Collaborative Program in Ancient and Medieval Philosophy (CPAMP)
- Dissertation: Thomas Aquinas' Philosophy of Memory
- 4.0 GPA
- Faculty of Arts and Sciences Top (FAST) fellow, and Canada Graduate Scholar (CGS-D)

MA, University of Toronto/Toronto School of Theology (TST) 2017-2018

- Thesis: The Three-fold Meaning of Memory in Thomas Aquinas' Philosophy
- 4.0 GPA

BA, philosophy major, theology minor 2004-07

- Thesis: The Relationship between Philosophy and Contemporary Scientific Psychology
- 3.72 GPA (*magna cum laude*)

WORK EXPERIENCE

Apollo Advancement (apolloadvancement.com) 2025-26

- Developed and launched an independent development consulting business. Created comprehensive processes and documents for a suite of development-focused services, including fractional fundraising support, development audit, campaign development and board and staff training. Built and launched apolloadvancement.com.
- The Peterborough Singers:
  - Developed and am executing a fundraising campaign for the Syd Birrell Legacy Fund to coincide with the retirement of the Singers' founding director.
  - Created all content for the campaign, including a 20-page magazine telling the story of the Peterborough Singers, the Case for Support, direct-mail letters, and social media and website content
  - Migrated the Singers from a deprecated, locally-hosted database to Little Green Light, and developed and trained staff and volunteers on CRM processes and best practices
  - Successfully raised the first stage goal of $100,000 by Dec. 2025 and increased active donors from 128 to 434. The campaign is ongoing.
- Bussey Ainsworth Lawyers
  - Developed and am executing a comprehensive 12-month digital marketing and business development strategy encompassing SEO, content production, backlink building, reputation management, community seminars, direct mail, referral partnership development.

- Designed and built a new firm website, completely reimagining the firm's brand presence and storytelling while optimizing for search engine performance, page speed, and mobile experience.
- Developed and am implementing a CRM strategy using Clio Grow and Clio Manage to streamline client intake, lead tracking, pipeline management, and marketing automation, reducing administrative burden on firm staff.
- Produced a full content library including practice area pages, blog posts, and FAQ resources, positioning the principal lawyer as a trusted authority in several uncontested legal niches.

Wayside Academy

Headmaster March 2023- Sept. 2025

- Responsible for overseeing all operational functions of the school, including recruiting, staffing, teacher training and evaluation, professional development, student behaviour, communications with parents, timetabling, budget formulation and management, marketing, and fundraising
- Developed and personally executed every aspect of a fundraising program that increased fundraising revenue from a previous best year of $280k to over $600k, and increased the number of active donors from just under 50 to over 300, in the first year in which the program ran.
- Made successful individual asks of major donors, including a gift of $150k and multiple gifts of $100k.
- Obtained significant media coverage for the school through a comprehensive marketing strategy involving public-facing events and personalized contact with local media
- Successfully rolled out the first significant tuition rate increase in over a decade and a half, contributing to long-term financial security and stability for the school
- Instituted the first significant pay increase for teachers in over a decade and a half, and achieved 100% staff retention (a first in the history of the school)
- Taught high school philosophy

LifeSiteNews

Managing Director/VP of Digital Marketing 2014-17

- Managed and coordinated the daily activities of all departments and up to 30 full-time and part-time staff and contractors, and a budget of over $2 million.
- Determined staffing needs and guided hiring priorities, led the search and hiring of new staff, and developed scalable HR policies and procedures to integrate, train, and regularly evaluate staff members
- Proposed, launched and personally managed LSN's marketing department from inception. Developed and implemented marketing strategies that increased web traffic by over 810%, from less than five million sessions (i.e. visits) per year in 2009, to over 44 million sessions per year in 2017
- Developed and implemented social media marketing strategies that increased social followers from zero to over 600,000, and e-mail acquisition strategies that increased e-mail contacts from 30,000 to over 500,000
- Worked closely with the VP of Development to develop fundraising strategy, set fundraising goals and benchmarks, and oversee quarterly fundraising campaigns. Implemented strategic, interest-based segmenting of social media and e-mail contacts for the purpose of delivering targeted fundraising appeals, contributing to consistent and significant year-over-year fundraising increases

Managing Editor 2012-14

- Oversaw and managed all aspects of the daily news operation, including hiring and training of staff

Assistant Editor 2009-12

- Edited news and opinion content for content, grammar, style and factual accuracy

ACADEMIC AWARDS

Congress Graduate Merit Award (CGMA), *Canadian Philosophical Association* 2025-26

Winner – ACPQ Rising Scholar Essay Contest 2023

Canada Graduate Scholarships—Doctoral Scholarships (CGS-D) 2019-22

$105,000

The objective of the Canada Graduate Scholarships – Doctoral (CGS D) program is to promote continued excellence in Canadian research by rewarding and retaining high-calibre doctoral students at Canadian institutions.

Faculty of Arts and Science Top (FAST), University of Toronto 2018-22

$88,000

This fellowship is designed to support the recruitment of the very best domestic students to PhD programs. The award is offered to a top incoming domestic PhD student for the first four years of the student's doctoral program.

Michael Steinhauser Scholarship, Toronto School of Theology 2018-22

Awarded to a graduate student with the highest academic achievement in the first year of studies.

ACADEMIC PRESENTATIONS

Invited

Aquinas and the Art of Memory

- Seat of Wisdom College, guest lecture — Jan. 2023
- Christendom College, philosophy department, guest lecture — Nov. 2021

Anselm on the Fall of the Devil and Free Will

- Guest lecture, Early Medieval Philosophy, University of Toronto — Sept. 2022

Aquinas on Memory

- Cologne-Toronto Graduate Student Colloquium — Sept. 2022

Aquinas on Memory and Recollection

- Collaborative Program in Ancient and Medieval Philosophy (CPAMP) work-in-progress group — Feb. 2022

Understanding the Vis Cogitativa Through the Via Negativa

- Toronto Colloquium in Medieval Philosophy (UTCMP) — Sept. 20223

Refereed

Averroes' Theory of the Progressive Spiritualisation of the Object of Sense in Aquinas's Psychology

- 58th International Congress on Medieval Studies, Kalamazoo — May 2023

The 'intentio' of pastness in Aquinas' theory of memory

- Canadian Philosophical Association Annual Congress — May 2023
- American Philosophical Association, Central Division — Feb. 2023

Memory, Cogitation and Experimentum in Pre-abstractive Cognition

- American Catholic Philosophical Association annual congress (poster) — Nov. 2022

Thomas Aquinas on Memory as the Foundation for Morality

- Issues in Philosophy of Memory 3, Duke University — Aug. 2022

The intentio in Averroes' philosophy of perception: a paradoxical cognitive object

- 57th International Congress on Medieval Studies — May 2022

The Problem of Willing Particulars in Aquinas' Action Theory

- Canadian Philosophical Association Annual Congress — May 2022
- American Philosophical Association, Central Division — Feb. 2022

The Vis Cogitativa: Aquinas' Neglected Cognitive Faculty

- Canadian Philosophical Association Annual Congress June 2021

The Phenomenological Challenge to Colour Relationalism

- Canadian Philosophical Association Annual Congress June 2020

(note: paper accepted but undelivered after conference cancelled due to Covid-19)

Is the Well-Trained Memory Morally Virtuous?: Thomas Aquinas and the Art of Memory

- American Philosophical Association, Central Division Feb. 2020
- Canadian Philosophical Association Annual Congress June 2019

TESTIMONIALS

"For 35 years I served as Artistic Director of the Peterborough Singers, a choir of 130 members that I founded. When I retired, it was suggested that a fund be established and money raised as a legacy to help the Choir with both transition and in moving forward once a new Artistic Director was chosen.

John Jalsevac was engaged by the board to run this campaign, which became known as the Syd Birrell Legacy Fund. In five short weeks, under John's guidance, we raised over $100,000 more than double any campaign total we had run in the previous 35 years. The campaign is still ongoing, and that number continues to grow.

John is smart, compassionate, intuitive, hard-working, and extremely knowledgeable when it comes to the art of fundraising. He is well connected and diligent. He is a leader. His writing is extraordinary. He has the ability to find stories that matter in the lives of both audience members and choir members as they relate to the Peterborough Singers, and to write extraordinary articles which are then shared in newsletters before the real asking for money even happens. This establishes great interest and arouses the desire to help financially.

John knows the databases and other tools of the trade that are necessary to track donations. He knows how to research and identify donors of high net worth. He speaks very well to our audiences during concerts.

I can wholeheartedly recommend John as the person an organization wants to run a campaign and handle every facet of that project. I am happy to take questions from prospective organizations."

Syd Birrell
Founder & Artistic Director (retired), The Peterborough Singers

"When John came on board, we had about 50 donors and no real fundraising infrastructure or strategy. Within a year, he'd grown our donor base to over 300 and more than doubled our annual revenue. He developed our case for support, launched our first direct mail campaign in years, and professionalized every aspect of how we engaged supporters.

For a small organization with limited resources, having someone who could think strategically and also execute was invaluable. And it's worth noting - during this time, John was also serving as our headmaster, building out numerous other systems that resulted in record student enrollment and 100% teacher retention, while also teaching. The fact that he accomplished more in fundraising as essentially a side responsibility than many full-time development professionals might in the same period says something about how efficiently and effectively he works.

Oh, and did I mention that he promised to jump into our local Peterborough lake, in January (remember: this is Canada!), if we successfully hit our campaign goal. And when we did, he did. And, he somehow convinced me to join him in this crazy scheme. I can vouch that the water was frigid. But, that's the kind of personal, skin-in-the-game commitment he brings to his clients."

Frank Callaghan
Former Board Chair, Wayside Academy